How costumes in the new 'Sense and Sensibility' show two sisters sharing clothes

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A new movie version of "Sense and Sensibility," based on Jane Austen's first novel, is now in theaters. It follows two sisters: sensible Elinor, played by Daisy Edgar-Jones, and romantic Marianne, played by Esmé Creed-Miles. **Costume designer** Grace Snell told IndieWire how she used clothes to tell their story.

The story takes place in the **Regency era** in England, more than 200 years ago. Snell had never designed costumes for a historical film before. She did deep research on the period, but she also wanted the clothes to feel modern. She was inspired by fashion from the 1990s and early 2000s, which had a similar shape to dresses from Austen's time.

Her biggest idea came from real life: sisters often borrow each other's clothes. After the Dashwood family has to leave its home and move to a small cottage in Devonshire, the sisters share, adapt and mix their outfits.

Snell said she could tell the two actors' characters apart right away at their first **fittings**. Elinor's fitting was organized and labeled. For Marianne, Snell brought boxes of ribbons, **trims** and hats and let the actor dress herself, even if things were not done up correctly. Marianne ends up with a playful, slightly **rebellious** style, including old dresses that are a bit too big.

Snell also gave both sisters jackets cut from the same pattern, in the same color but different **fabrics**. Elinor's jacket was made longer. "They could wear the same outfit, but they were styled differently," Snell said.

The cheerful Mrs. Jennings, played by Fiona Shaw, got bold outfits too. "I had a lot of fun with Fiona," Snell said.

Word Treasure

costume designer -- A costume designer plans and creates the clothes that actors wear in a movie or play.

Regency era -- The Regency era was a period in England more than 200 years ago, known for its elegant fashion.

fittings -- Fittings are sessions where actors try on clothes so they can be adjusted to fit.

trims -- Trims are decorations such as lace or braid that are sewn onto clothes.

rebellious -- Rebellious describes someone who does not follow the usual rules or expectations.

fabrics -- Fabrics are cloth materials, such as cotton or wool, used to make clothes.

Background you need

Jane Austen was an English writer whose novels about family, love and manners are still read and turned into movies today.

"Sense and Sensibility" is about two sisters with very different personalities, one careful and practical, the other emotional and romantic.

Costume designers research the clothing of a story's time period, then design outfits that also help show each character's personality.

In the Regency era, women's dresses often had a high waistline, a shape that also became popular again in later fashion.

Break it down

LEAD: Costumes in the new "Sense and Sensibility" help tell the story of two sisters.
KEY EVENT: Costume designer Grace Snell explains her approach to IndieWire
+- WHO: Elinor (Daisy Edgar-Jones) and Marianne (Esmé Creed-Miles)
+- WHEN: The story is set in Regency-era England
BIG IDEA: Sisters borrow and mix each other's clothes, especially after moving to a cottage in Devonshire
EVIDENCE: Organized fittings for Elinor; ribbons, trims and hats for Marianne
DETAIL: Matching jackets in the same color but different fabrics
EXTRA: Bold outfits for Mrs. Jennings, played by Fiona Shaw

Why it matters

The story shows how clothes in movies are carefully planned to show characters' personalities and relationships, not just the time period.

Test what you remember

1. Who plays Elinor in the movie?

- (A) Daisy Edgar-Jones
- (B) Fiona Shaw
- (C) Esmé Creed-Miles
- (D) Grace Snell

2. Which decades of fashion inspired Grace Snell?

- (A) The 1920s and 1930s
- (B) The 1950s and 1960s
- (C) Only the 1800s
- (D) The 1990s and early 2000s

3. What real-life idea shaped the costumes?

- (A) Sisters often borrow each other's clothes
- (B) Only new clothes look good
- (C) Clothes should always match
- (D) Everyone wears uniforms

4. How did Snell run Marianne's fitting?

- (A) She skipped the fitting
- (B) She used only black dresses
- (C) She brought ribbons, trims and hats and let the actor dress herself
- (D) She labeled every piece

5. What was different about the sisters' matching jackets?

- (A) One had no sleeves
- (B) They were made in different fabrics, and Elinor's was longer
- (C) They came from different stores
- (D) They were different colors

6. Where does the family move after leaving its home?

- (A) A farm in America
- (B) A ship
- (C) A small cottage in Devonshire
- (D) A castle in London

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: A 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Costume designer Grace Snell: Wanted the historical costumes to feel modern and to show how sisters share clothes.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):